

Solitude: An Additional Strategy in Art

Introduction

Art, in whatever form it may be presented, has the ability to make viewers feel a certain way. Whether it be a painting of a sunset at seaside that makes you feel relaxed and calm, or a song so grandiose in its composition that it overwhelms you.

The artworks that are the focus of this paper all use this ability to make the viewer feel a specific feeling. That being, solitude. For some of the pieces covered, this solitude takes the shape of loneliness, which is accompanied by a degree of sadness. For others, it simply makes the viewer feel solitary, without it necessarily being sombre. However, to qualify as a strategy, the concept of solitude must also be an integral part of the making of the artwork. For example, the artist might intentionally try to convey solitude in their piece, but it could also be the case that the artist lived a particularly solitary life, which might have influenced their art. This paper intends to introduce and discuss various artworks that exhibit this strategy of solitude.

“Nighthawks” – Edward Hopper

Edward Hopper, born in 1882, is one of the most famous artists to come from the United States. He was inspired by French impressionist artists such as Édouard Manet and Edgar Degas and even said that he considered himself an impressionist (Jenkins, 2006). However, Hopper is primarily considered a realist painter, as his paintings depicted contemporary every-day American life. Still, Hopper tended to simplify shapes and stray away from photorealistic details. In fact, barring portraits, the facial features of many of his characters are quite bare basic, sometimes even being borderline non-existent. An example of this can be seen in “Room in New York”, which depicts a male and female figure with obscured faces ignoring each other. This juxtaposition of impressionist and realist elements has led some to aptly describe his art as ‘soft realism’ (This Decisive Moment, 2022).

Many of Hopper’s pieces are often described to have strong themes of solitude (Gopnik, 2022). This includes his most famous one, “Nighthawks”, which is the first artwork this paper discusses. In “Nighthawks”, we see a picture of a diner of sorts during the night. Inside the diner, four unknown people are present. The man on the right, being positioned behind the bar and wearing a uniform of sorts is presumably an employee at the establishment. He glances at the man and woman sitting next to each other, their slightly overlapping hands suggesting that they are there together. However, the man’s void expression coupled with the woman’s less than enthused demeanour imply that,

while they may be physically together, they seem to lack a deeper connection. Finally, the man sitting alone to the left of the other characters shows his back to the audience. Even without a look at his face, though, the distance between him and the others strengthens this feeling of solitude.

Furthermore, the perspective chosen for this artwork also emboldens the theme of solitude. Positioned outside of the diner, which is the only source of light, we as the viewer can merely gaze into the scene, as if we were passing by the establishment during a nightly walk. The lack of a visible entrance into the diner emphasizes this barrier between the viewer and the characters inside.

This sense of solitude in “Nighthawks” and many of Hopper’s other paintings can be traced back to his personal life. He was known to be a shy boy growing up, and that introverted personality stuck with him as he grew older (Mannino, 2023). Known as someone who did not speak much, Hopper was usually found in his studio overlooking Washington Square like a hawk. And even though he was often with his wife, Josephine Nivison, domestic violence and sexual dissatisfaction led to a rather solitary marriage as well. In fact, the emotional distance between the male and female figures in “Room in New York” and “Nighthawks” can be interpreted as a representation of the couple’s marriage. Hopper himself seems to recognize this solitary aspect of his life. In response to a question about the absence of human subjects in many of his art pieces, he said that it was “probably a reflection of my own, if I may say, loneliness” (Smith, 2024).



Figure 1: "Nighthawks", 1942 - Edward Hopper

“Untitled” – Vasudeo Santu Gaitonde

The next work this paper discusses is another painting by artist who lived a life arguably even more solitary than Hopper. Vasudeo Santu Gaitonde, also referred to as VS Gaitonde, was an Indian abstract artist born in 1924. Cutting ties with his family at a young age, Gaitonde lived a life of solitude, although this was not necessarily something he enjoyed as he grew older. A close friend of him has said that Gaitonde was actually suffering of loneliness (Artiana, n.d.). This isolation complemented his quiet disposition, as he was known as a recluse and rarely talked to media about his works, leading to a lack of information about his life.

As an artist, Gaitonde valued the concept of silence above everything else, stemming from his proclivity for Zen Buddhism. In practice, he has been known to sit on a certain bench and stare out at the sea for hours on end in complete silence, even when joined by another artist friend of his (Mohta, 2019). Silence, which in Gaitonde’s case was often a by-product of his solitude, is therefore a key component of many of his artworks. The artwork this paper focuses on is Gaitonde’s “Untitled”, created in 1960.

“Untitled” shows the viewer Gaitonde’s love for the sea he spent so much time silently gazing at in an abstract way. On the left, a sailboat is pictured with a faint reflection in what can be interpreted as the sea. To the right side we see a blue circle, seemingly representing either the moon during its descent, or rather simply the moon’s reflection. While the background itself is very textured and varies slightly in hue and brightness all over the canvas, there are not any other objects to be found.

Viewing this artwork instills the same sense of quiet and solitude Gaitonde must have felt when he gazed at the sea all those years ago, almost feeling as an invitation from Gaitonde to look at the same scenery. The choice to not paint the sea itself emphasizes the stillness, as it does not distract the viewer with extra details, allowing them to imagine the water themselves. The same can be said for the lack of a visible sky with clouds or stars which may detract from the impact the sailboat and moon can have on the viewer.

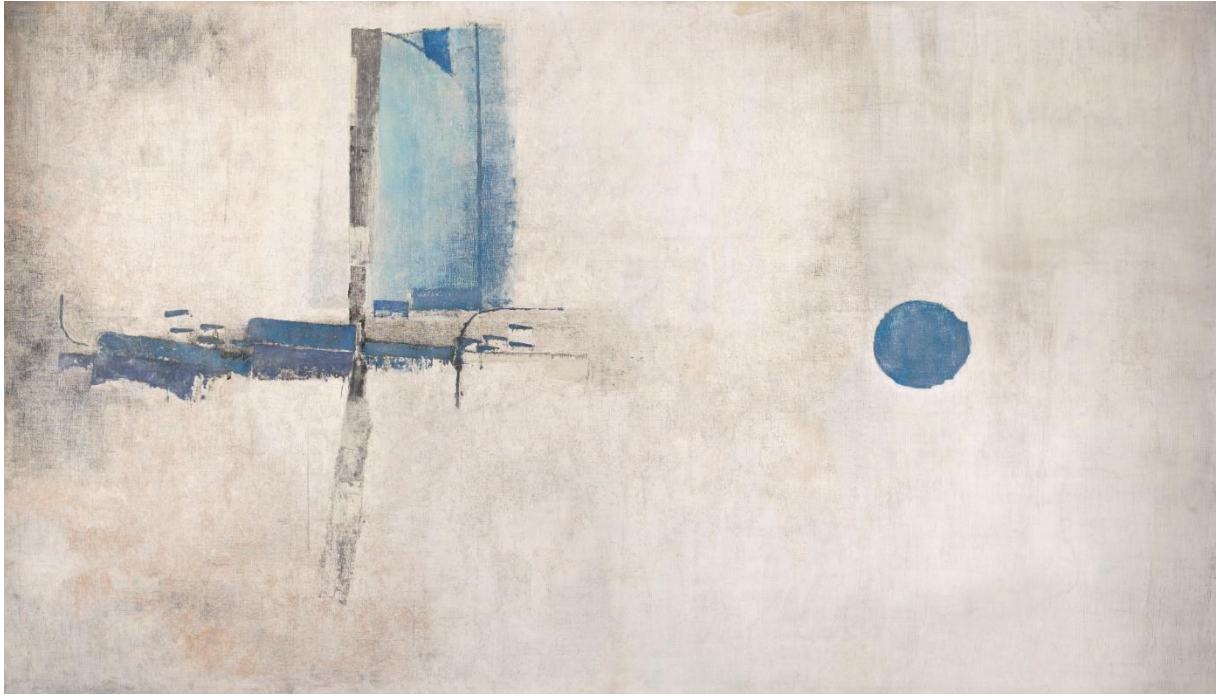


Figure 2: "Untitled", 1960 - Vasudeo Santu Gaitonde

“Cage Piece” – Tehching Hsieh

Tehching Hsieh, born on the last day of 1950, is a Taiwanese performance artist known for his extremely long and taxing performances. A central theme of many of his works is the passage of time. An example of this would be his year-long performance called ‘Time Clock Piece’, in which he promised to punch a time clock every hour on the hour, taking a photo at same time, for an entire year. ‘Time Clock Piece’ exemplifies Hsieh’s commitment to his art, as he puts his health on the line by practically forgoing sleep for an extended period of time. The work this paper discusses, however, also puts a strong emphasis on the concept of solitude.

Being the first of his one year-long performances, ‘Cage Piece’ entailed Hsieh locking himself up in a cage with an area of less than 10m² between September 30th of 1978 and September 29th of the following year. Hsieh would also take a picture of himself every day, documenting how he was affected by the passage of time. A friend of his would deliver any necessary items such as food and water, and take care of his waste, but other than that, Hsieh was completely solitary for the entire year. He did not even allow himself any entertainment, promising that he would not converse, read, write, listen to the radio or watch television until the day the performance would end. There was quite literally nothing to do for Hsieh besides moving his body in the small cage, think, or sleep. After being asked if the experience was boring, Hsieh responded that the first few days can be boring, but staying there for a whole year is a completely different feeling

altogether (Groom, 2013). He would go on to say that, if you were not thinking actively about surviving the year, one could lose their mind.

Hsieh has often said that the main essence of his one year-long performances is the passing of time and the so-called boundary between 'art time' and 'life time' (Cummings, 2017). While this is clearly the case when looking at his performances, one cannot deny the profound presence of solitude in his works. This is especially the case in "Cage Piece", seemingly trumping the theme of time due to the harsh restrictions placed on Hsieh's ability to interact with the outside world (e.g., no conversing).

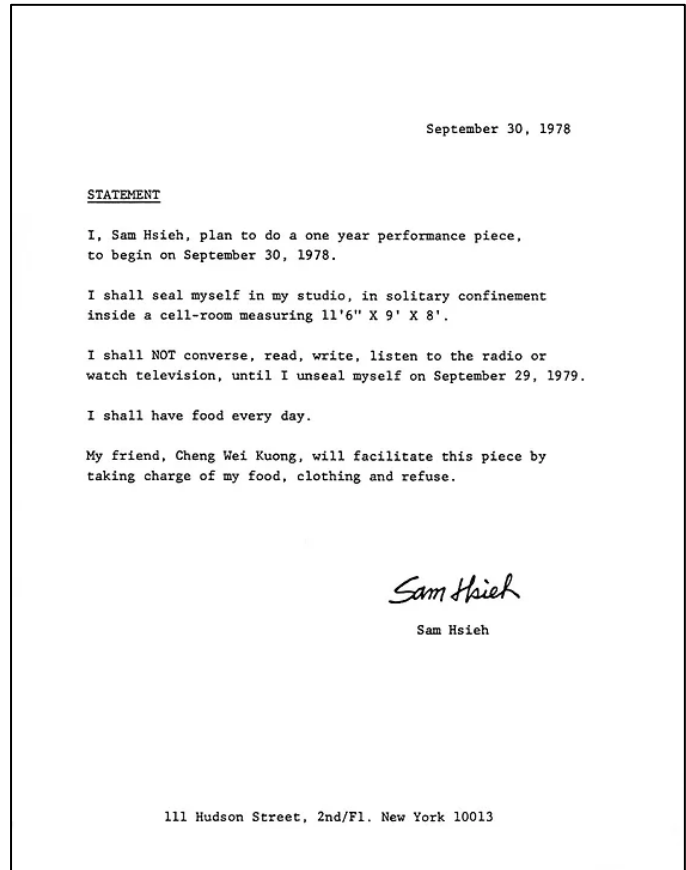


Figure 3: The letter describing all the rules for "Cage Piece"



Figure 4: "Cage Piece", 1978 – Tehching Hsieh

“Fireflies on the Water” – Yayoi Kusama

Born in 1929 in Japan, Yayoi Kusama is a world-renowned artist famous for many different types of art ranging from paintings and sculptures to performance art and fashion. However, the two artistic expressions she is mostly known for are artworks involving copious amounts of polka-dots and installations focused on making viewers feel as if they have entered a room with no boundaries, also called infinity installations.

Ever since she was a child, Kusama grappled with a mental disease that made her hallucinate and depressed (Mert, 2022). Frequently, these hallucinations would come to her in the form of dots, overwhelming her to such an extent that she felt as if she were in an infinitely large room. This mental disease, alongside an unhealthy home environment, led to Kusama living a lonely childhood. However, Kusama seemingly embraced this aspect of her life and embraced the solitude, turning it into a well of inspiration for her art. A great example of this “Fireflies on the Water”, one of her previously mentioned infinity installations.

“Fireflies on the Water”, made in 2002, is a room shaped like a cube with mirrors lining all four walls and the ceiling while the floor is covered with a layer of water. What makes the room special, however, are the numerous hanging lights strewn about the space at different heights, reflecting off the water and mirrors resulting in an infinite number of copies. The viewer, who is only allowed to enter the room alone, has limited space to move, only being able to stand on a wooden



Figure 5: “Fireflies on the Water”, 2002 – Yayoi Kusama

pathway resembling a boat. Along with the water, this makes the viewer feel as if they are floating in the middle of the sea during a particularly starry night. One could also view this experience as being suspended deep in space, surrounded by the stars and a universal infinity. The lack of any sound whatsoever emphasizes the immersion one feels in this room, seemingly being transported into a different world. The fact that only one person can enter at any given moment, indicates that solitude is an important aspect of this installation. This makes perfect sense, as having someone else with you in such a confined space can distract you from the atmosphere so carefully created. Another way

of interpreting this piece is as a look into Kusama's personal world. The tiny lights repeating ad infinitum mimic the dots that Kusama often saw in her hallucinations, and the feeling of being in a boundless room is also something she has experienced before.

Conclusion

This paper covered four artworks by Edward Hopper, Vasudeo Santu Gaitonde, Tehching Hsieh, and Yayoi Kusama and argued that they all used the concept of solitude as a strategy when creating these pieces. While this paper only covered these four, there are doubtlessly many more examples to be found. Especially with the COVID-19 pandemic being recent history, it would not be surprising if there is an influx in art grappling with this concept.

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